

ACME CORPORATION

HUMAN RESOURCES POLICY HANDBOOK

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1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE

This HR Policy Handbook sets out Acme Corporation's policies and procedures relating to all aspects of employment. It applies to all permanent, fixed-term, part-time, and contract employees across all offices and locations. Contractors and agency workers are covered by specific sections noted within each policy. This handbook should be read in conjunction with individual employment contracts and any departmental operating procedures.

2. EMPLOYEE ONBOARDING PROCESS

Acme Corporation follows a structured 90-day onboarding programme for all new employees. The onboarding process is managed jointly by HR, the hiring manager, and the IT department.

2.1 Pre-Joining Requirements

The following must be completed before the employee's first day:

- Signed employment contract returned to HR at least 5 business days before start date
- Right to work documentation verified (passport, visa, work permit)
- Background check completed (criminal record check, reference verification)
- Bank account details submitted for payroll setup (Form HR-003)
- Emergency contact information submitted (Form HR-004)
- IT equipment request submitted to IT Helpdesk at least 5 business days before start date
- Laptop, access card, email account, and system access provisioned by IT

2.2 Day 1 Onboarding Checklist

Activity	Owner	Timing
Welcome meeting with HR	HR Business Partner	9:00 AM Day 1
Introduction to direct manager	Hiring Manager	10:00 AM Day 1
Office and facilities tour	HR / Facilities	11:00 AM Day 1
IT systems access and laptop setup	IT Helpdesk	Day 1
Health & Safety induction	H&S Manager	Day 1
Mandatory compliance training	HR / Compliance	Week 1

Meet the team lunch	Hiring Manager	Day 1 or 2
30-day check-in with HR	HR Business Partner	Day 30
60-day performance review	Hiring Manager	Day 60
90-day probation review	Hiring Manager + HR	Day 90

2.3 Probation Period

- All new employees serve a 90-day probation period (extendable to 180 days in exceptional circumstances)
- During probation, either party may terminate employment with 1 week written notice
- Probation review meetings are held at Day 30, Day 60, and Day 90
- Successful probation completion is confirmed in writing by HR within 5 business days of the Day 90 review
- Failed probation: employee receives written notice and has right to appeal within 5 business days

3. LEAVE POLICY

3.1 Annual Leave Entitlement

Years of Service	Annual Leave (Days)	Carry Over (Max)	Buy/Sell Scheme
0 – 2 years	25 days	5 days	Up to 5 days
2 – 5 years	27 days	5 days	Up to 5 days
5 – 10 years	30 days	8 days	Up to 8 days
10+ years	33 days	10 days	Up to 10 days
Senior Manager+	35 days	10 days	Up to 10 days

3.2 Annual Leave Rules

- Annual leave requests must be submitted in the HR system (HR Portal) at least 5 business days in advance
- Requests of 5+ consecutive days require 10 business days advance notice
- Manager approval is required for all leave; approval/rejection within 3 business days
- No more than 3 employees from the same team may be on leave simultaneously during peak periods
- Unused leave above the carry-over maximum is forfeited at year end (31 December)
- Leave during notice period: employer may require employee to use remaining leave during notice period

3.3 Sick Leave Policy

- All employees receive 15 days paid sick leave per calendar year
- Sick leave for 1-2 consecutive days: self-certification via HR Portal required on return
- Sick leave for 3+ consecutive days: medical certificate required from a registered doctor
- Long-term sickness (4+ weeks): HR will initiate formal absence management process
- Unused sick leave does not carry over to the next year and is not paid out on termination
- Acme Corporation operates a Return to Work interview for all absences of 3+ consecutive days

3.4 Maternity Leave

- Eligible employees: 26 weeks enhanced maternity pay (100% salary for weeks 1-13, 50% for weeks 14-26)
- Statutory Maternity Pay (SMP) continues for weeks 27-39 at the statutory rate
- Total maternity leave entitlement: 52 weeks (26 weeks Ordinary + 26 weeks Additional)
- Eligibility: employed for 26 weeks by the 15th week before expected due date
- Notice: must inform HR in writing by week 25 of pregnancy with MATB1 certificate
- Keeping in touch (KIT) days: up to 10 KIT days during maternity leave at full daily rate

3.5 Paternity and Shared Parental Leave

- Paternity leave: 2 weeks paid at 100% salary within 8 weeks of birth/adoption
- Shared parental leave: up to 50 weeks shareable between parents, up to 37 weeks at SMP rate
- Adoption leave: same rights as maternity leave for primary adopter
- Fertility treatment leave: up to 5 days paid leave per treatment cycle

3.6 Other Leave Types

Leave Type	Entitlement	Approval Required	Paid/Unpaid
Bereavement	5 days immediate family; 3 days extended family	Manager	Paid
Compassionate	Up to 5 days	HR Director	Paid
Study / Exam	Up to 5 days per year	Manager + HR	Paid
Volunteering	3 days per year	Manager	Paid
Jury Duty	Full duration required	HR (notify only)	Paid
Emergency Dependent	Up to 3 days	Manager (inform)	Paid
Unpaid Leave	Up to 4 weeks	Director + HR	Unpaid
Sabbatical	Up to 6 months (5yr+ service)	CEO + HR Director	Partial/Unpaid

4. WORK FROM HOME (WFH) POLICY

Acme Corporation operates a hybrid working model. Employees are expected to be in the office for a minimum number of days per week based on their role category.

Role Category	Office Days/Week	WFH Days/Week	WFH Equipment Provided
Individual Contributor	2 days	3 days	Laptop, monitor allowance
Team Lead / Manager	3 days	2 days	Laptop only
Director and above	4 days	1 day	Laptop only
Customer-facing roles	5 days	0 days	N/A
Technical / Engineering	2 days	3 days	Laptop, peripherals allowance

- WFH days must be agreed with direct manager and logged in the HR Portal
- Employees must be reachable during core hours: 9:30 AM – 4:30 PM (local time)
- WFH equipment allowance: up to £500 one-time setup allowance, receipts required
- Internet allowance: £30/month for employees working 3+ days from home
- WFH arrangements may be withdrawn if performance, security, or team collaboration is impacted

5. PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT

5.1 Performance Review Cycle

- Annual performance reviews are conducted every January for the preceding calendar year
- Mid-year check-in (informal) is conducted every July
- New employees have 30-day, 60-day, and 90-day probation reviews
- Continuous feedback is encouraged via the HR Portal's 360-feedback tool

5.2 Performance Rating Scale

Rating	Description	Outcome
5 – Exceptional	Consistently exceeds all objectives	Top performer bonus + fast-track promotion
4 – Exceeds	Frequently exceeds most objectives	Above-average salary increase + bonus
3 – Meets	Meets all objectives as expected	Standard salary increase + bonus
2 – Developing	Partially meets objectives	Performance Improvement Plan (PIP)
1 – Underperforms	Fails to meet minimum expectations	Formal warning + PIP — risk of dismissal

6. EXPENSE REIMBURSEMENT POLICY

- All business expenses must be submitted within 30 days of being incurred

- Expenses submitted more than 90 days after incurring are not reimbursable without Director approval
- All claims above £25 require an original receipt or e-receipt
- Travel expenses: economy class for flights under 5 hours; business class permitted for 5+ hours with Director approval
- Hotel accommodation: up to £200 per night in London; £150 elsewhere in UK; £250 internationally
- Daily meal allowance: £15 breakfast, £25 lunch, £40 dinner (when travelling for business)
- Mileage rate: 45p per mile for first 10,000 miles, 25p per mile thereafter (private car)
- Mobile phone allowance: £50/month for employees required to use personal phone for work
- Expense reports submitted via HR Portal — manager approval required before Finance processing

7. DISCIPLINARY PROCEDURE

Acme Corporation follows a fair and transparent disciplinary procedure in line with ACAS guidelines. The procedure applies to all employees and is designed to be corrective rather than punitive.

7.1 Disciplinary Levels

Level	Examples	Duration on Record
Informal verbal warning	Minor lateness, minor conduct issues	6 months
Formal verbal warning	Repeated minor issues, poor timekeeping	6 months
First written warning	Unauthorised absence, minor misconduct	12 months
Final written warning	Gross misconduct (first instance), repeated	24 months
Dismissal	Gross misconduct, fraud, violence, harassment	Permanent

8. EMPLOYEE OFFBOARDING PROCESS

When an employee leaves Acme Corporation (resignation, redundancy, retirement, or dismissal), the following offboarding process must be completed.

8.1 Notice Periods

Seniority Level	Employee Notice	Employer Notice
0 – 2 years service	1 month	1 month
2 – 5 years service	2 months	2 months
5 – 10 years service	3 months	3 months
10+ years service	3 months	4 months
Director and above	6 months	6 months
During probation	1 week	1 week

8.2 Offboarding Checklist

- Employee submits written resignation to direct manager and HR
- Exit interview scheduled with HR within first week of notice period
- Knowledge transfer plan agreed with manager and completed before last day
- IT notified: all system access revoked on last working day at 5:00 PM
- All company equipment (laptop, phone, access card) returned on last day — receipt issued
- Final payroll includes: remaining salary, unused holiday payout (up to carry-over max), any outstanding expenses
- P45 issued within 5 business days of final working day
- Reference requests: HR provides factual references (dates of employment, job title) — no opinion references
- Non-disclosure and post-employment obligations remain in force as per employment contract

9. TRAINING AND DEVELOPMENT

- All employees receive a mandatory training budget of £1,500 per year for professional development
- Senior Manager and above: £3,000 per year training budget
- Training requests must be approved by direct manager and submitted via HR Portal
- Mandatory training (compliance, H&S, data protection): completed within 30 days of joining, renewed annually
- Study leave: up to 5 days per year for job-relevant exams and courses with manager approval
- Sponsorship for professional qualifications (ACCA, CIPD, PMP, etc.): available on case-by-case basis with 2-year service commitment post-qualification
- Mentoring programme: all employees eligible to request a mentor after 6 months service

10. FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Q: What is the employee onboarding process?

A: New employees follow a structured 90-day onboarding programme including pre-joining checks (right to work, background check, IT setup), Day 1 induction, weekly meetings with manager, and formal reviews at Day 30, Day 60, and Day 90. HR manages the overall process and the hiring manager oversees daily integration.

Q: How many days annual leave do I get?

A: Annual leave entitlement starts at 25 days for employees with 0-2 years service, increasing to 27 days (2-5 years), 30 days (5-10 years), and 33 days for 10+ years. Senior Managers and above receive 35 days. Plus 8 UK bank holidays.

Q: How do I request annual leave?

A: Submit your leave request through the HR Portal with at least 5 business days notice (10 days for 5+ consecutive days). Your manager will approve or decline within 3 business days. No more than 3 members of the same team may be on leave simultaneously.

Q: How many sick days am I entitled to?

A: All employees receive 15 days paid sick leave per calendar year. For absences of 1-2 days, complete self-certification on return. For 3+ consecutive days, a medical certificate from a registered doctor is required. Unused sick leave does not carry over.

Q: What is the work from home policy?

A: Acme operates a hybrid model. Individual contributors and technical/engineering roles work 2 days in office and 3 days from home per week. Team leads and managers work 3 days in office. Directors work 4 days in office. A one-time WFH equipment allowance of up to £500 is provided, plus £30/month internet allowance for those working 3+ days from home.

Q: How do I raise a disciplinary concern or grievance?

A: For disciplinary matters, contact your HR Business Partner directly at hr@acmecorp.com. For grievances, submit a formal grievance letter to HR. All matters are treated confidentially. Acme follows ACAS guidelines and all employees have the right to be accompanied at formal hearings.

Q: What is the notice period if I resign?

A: Notice periods depend on length of service: 1 month (0-2 years), 2 months (2-5 years), 3 months (5-10 years), and 3 months for 10+ years. Directors and above serve 6 months notice. During probation, notice is 1 week on either side.

Q: What maternity leave am I entitled to?

A: Eligible employees receive 26 weeks enhanced maternity pay (100% salary for weeks 1-13, 50% for weeks 14-26), followed by statutory rate for weeks 27-39. Total maternity leave is 52 weeks. You must notify HR in writing by week 25 of pregnancy with your MATB1 certificate.

Q: How do I claim expenses?

A: Submit expense claims through the HR Portal within 30 days of incurring the expense. Claims over £25 require a receipt. Manager approval is required before Finance processes the payment. Accommodation limits are £200/night in London and £150 elsewhere in UK. Meal allowances are £15 breakfast, £25 lunch, and £40 dinner when travelling on business.

Q: What training budget do I have?

A: All employees receive £1,500 per year for professional development (£3,000 for Senior Managers and above). Training requests must be approved by your manager via the HR Portal. Up to 5 days paid study leave is available per year for job-relevant courses and exams.

11. HR CONTACTS AND GOVERNANCE

11.1 Key HR Contacts

Query Type	Contact	Email	Response
General HR queries	HR Helpdesk	hr@acmecorp.com	1 business day
Leave requests	HR Portal	hrportal.acmecorp.com	Automated
Payroll queries	Payroll Team	payroll@acmecorp.com	2 business days
Onboarding	HR Business Partner	hrbp@acmecorp.com	1 business day
Disciplinary / Grievance	HR Director	hrdirector@acmecorp.com	Same day
Confidential matters	Employee Helpline	0800-ACME-HR (free)	Same day
Training & development	L&D Team	learning@acmecorp.com	2 business days

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